Team Launch

Get a new team or initiative ready to deliver in one or two weeks, and deliver something real while you do it.

Set Up the Team · Often Called Sprint Zero or Iteration 0 · Timeboxed · Thin First Slice

WORKED EXAMPLE · FICTIONAL TEAM

TEAM: Basket team

LAUNCH DATES: 17–28 February

1 Launch Goal

THE LAUNCH IS DONE WHEN…

We'll start delivering by Monday 3 March *and by then we will have:*

a charter, a backlog ready for two iterations, and the last-order card on staging

2 Timebox

SHORT ON PURPOSE

- [ ] 1 week
- [x] 2 weeks
- [ ] Other:

Launch owner: Tom

Daily check-in at: 09:30

3 Launch Checklist

TICK WHEN DONE · EACH ITEM LINKS TO A TOOL · DO JUST ENOUGH

Why & What

- [x] Purpose and problem agreed
  → Project Kickoff
  Owner: Priya
- [x] Product vision written
  → Product Vision Board
  Owner: Priya
- [x] Users understood
  → Persona & Journey Map
  Owner: Mei
- [ ] Outcomes and measures
  → Impact Map · OKRs
  Owner: Priya (week 2)
- [x] Stakeholders mapped
  → Stakeholder Map
  Owner: Tom

The Team

- [x] Charter and working agreements
  → Team Charter
  Owner: Tom
- [x] Roles and accountability clear
  → RACI & Decision Log
  Owner: Priya
- [x] Skills and gaps known
  → Skills Matrix
  Owner: Tom
- [x] AI use agreed
  → AI Working Agreement
  Owner: Sam
- [x] Decision rights agreed
  → Delegation Board
  Owner: Priya

The Backlog

- [x] Journey and first release slice
  → User Story Map
  Owner: Mei
- [x] Epic shaped, with an MVP
  → Epic Breakdown Canvas
  Owner: Priya
- [x] Items right-sized
  → Story Splitting · Backlog Item Anatomy
  Owner: Sam
- [x] Top items understood
  → Example Mapping
  Owner: Alex
- [ ] First forecast range
  → Release Forecast
  Owner: Tom (week 2)

Ways of Working

- [x] Board, workflow and WIP limits
  → Kanban Board Design
  Owner: Tom
- [x] Definition of Done agreed
  → Team Charter
  Owner: Alex
- [x] Cadence and events booked
  → Sprint Planning · Review · Retro
  Owner: Tom
- [ ] Risks named and owned
  → Pre-mortem · RAID Log
  Owner: Priya (week 2)
- [x] First retro booked
  → Retrospective Kit
  Owner: Tom

4 Thin First Slice

DELIVER SOMETHING REAL

However small, finish something a user could see or use.

Slice: last-order card on the home page (read-only)

Who it's for: returning customers in the test group

Done when: it shows a real last order on staging

- [x] It runs end to end, from input to output (a walking skeleton)

5 Environment & Tools

EVERYONE CAN WORK ON DAY ONE

- [x] Code repository and access for everyone
- [x] Build and deploy pipeline to a test environment
- [x] Team board set up in the team's tool
- [x] Shared channel, calendar and document space
- [x] Development setup works on every machine
- [ ] Test data and environments available ← still missing

6 Ready to Start?

THE EXIT CHECK

- [x] Vision and first outcome agreed
- [x] Top of the backlog ready for 1–2 iterations
- [x] Definition of Done agreed
- [x] First slice planned or already done
- [ ] Everyone can contribute from day one ← once test data is ready

Watch for: running past the timebox · designing everything up front · delivering nothing

"What's the least we need to agree before we can start delivering?"

"What could we deliver this week, however small?"

© 2026 Eric Parker · CC BY 4.0 · eparker71.github.io/better-delivery-toolkit